2010, also saw a widening of that sex imbalance, despite growth of the middle class. This should not be happening. In most development models, as a country becomes richer, its sex ratio evens out. In India, though, that gap has not narrowed, even though the rate at which it is widening did indeed slow over the past decade. Today's sex ratio of 914 females to every 1,000 males under age six ranks among the worst in the world.[7] Yet at the same time, decades of such a skewed sex imbalance make eligible young women an increasingly prized asset for males like Sita's fiancé.

The whole situation is her fault, she says, since her parents badgered her for years, ever since she was a teenager, to begin looking at an arranged marriage. She put them off numerous times and finally agreed, if only to end their exasperation. Her husband-to-be was the first one they looked at, and he said yes immediately. Sita doubts she'll bridge the age gap between them, and she's not even interested in trying. "I'm a quiet person," she says. "I don't talk to my parents much, since all they do is criticize me. So, I probably will talk to my husband when he talks to me." And yet, I muse, she is comfortable talking to a stranger about some of the most personal issues in her life. Perhaps the fact that I have no connection to anyone she knows makes it easier for her to talk this way, though it does nothing to solve her problems.

India's colleges and universities are full of young women with professional goals like Sita. My first day in India, I visit the University of Madras (the venerable city name for Chennai), one of India's three oldest institutions of higher learning, established in 1857 by the British and modeled on the University of London. There, amid its red-brick colonial grandeur, I learn that over half of its four thousand undergraduates are female, and regularly some of its top performers. From one perspective, India has made rapid gains in higher education, with 46 percent of women enrolling in some type of college or university in 2016.[8] By comparison, Japan has had a century and a half of higher education for women, yet in 2018 just over 50 percent of women went to college.[9]

When I reach Calcutta a week later, I stop at the elite Presidency University, founded by the British in 1817. I meet Professor Amita